

Edinburgh Castle - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Castle Rock: Geology as Destiny

Edinburgh Castle stands on a 350-million-year-old volcanic plug whose crag-and-tail formation dictated the entire shape of the city — and its military history. With sheer basalt on three sides, the rock has carried fortifications for perhaps three thousand years, and the castle proper claims the title of most besieged place in Britain, with some twenty-six sieges. Two are worth carrying with you. In March 1314, months before Bannockburn, Thomas Randolph, Earl of Moray, retook the English-held castle by escalade up the “unclimbable” north face, guided by William Francis, a member of the garrison in earlier years who had pioneered the route on nocturnal visits to a woman in the town — thirty men, ladders, total surprise. Robert the Bruce then ordered the castle’s defenses slighted so the English could never hold it again, sparing only St Margaret’s Chapel — which is why that tiny Romanesque building, circa 1130, survives as the oldest structure in Edinburgh. The second is the Lang Siege of 1571 to 73, when the castle held out for Mary, Queen of Scots long after her cause was lost, ending only when English heavy guns reduced David’s Tower to rubble; the Half Moon Battery you see dominating the approach was built directly on and around the tower’s remains — the castle’s silhouette is literally a scar of that siege. Almost nothing you’ll walk through predates it except the chapel and the Great Hall; this is less a preserved castle than an accumulation of reconstructions, each following a catastrophe.

Tell Me More: The Castle as Working Fortress

Details that reward a second look as you walk the wards. The castle remains a working military site — the Army’s presence is real, not costumed — which is why it houses the National War Museum and regimental museums of the Royal Scots and Scots Greys; the Scots Greys’ gallery includes relics of their legendary charge at Waterloo. The Half Moon Battery’s guns point, tellingly, down the Royal Mile — the fortress’s real vulnerability was always the town side, and after the 1745 Jacobite rising (when Bonnie Prince Charlie held the city but never took the castle, its guns bombarding his supporters’ houses), the government re-engineered approaches to the castle with defense in mind. Below the Great Hall lie the vaults that held prisoners of war from the American Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars — the reconstructed prison displays doors carved with original graffiti including an early depiction of the Stars and Stripes cut by an American privateer’s sailor, and records of a thriving prisoner economy forging banknotes and carving bone trinkets for sale; there were escapes, including a mass breakout in 1811 through a hole in the south wall. The dog cemetery on the ramparts, garrison mascots since the 1840s, is best viewed from above near St Margaret’s Chapel. And a good arriving-fact for the esplanade: it hosts the Royal Edinburgh Military Tattoo each August — grandstands may already be under construction as you visit — and was legally deemed Nova Scotian territory in the 1620s so Scottish colonists’ baronets could be created “on” their lands; Nova Scotia’s flag is the Scottish saltire reversed, a colonial echo that began on this parade ground.

A Volcano Carved by Ice

It’s worth pausing on the rock itself, because the geology here isn’t background scenery, it’s the reason for everything. What you’re standing on is the plug of a volcano that was active around three hundred

and forty million years ago, in the Carboniferous period, when this part of Scotland sat near the equator under warm, shallow seas. The eruptions themselves are long gone, eroded to nothing. What survived is the throat of the volcano, the column of magma that solidified inside the vent into a hard, dark igneous rock called dolerite, closely related to basalt. It's dense, tough, and stubbornly resistant to weathering, which is the whole point.

Then came the ice. During the last great glaciation, an ice sheet perhaps hundreds of metres thick flowed across this landscape, and crucially it moved from west to east. When that grinding mass of ice met the volcanic plug, it couldn't shear it away. Instead it was forced to split and flow around the obstacle, scouring deep hollows on either side, the troughs that today hold Princes Street Gardens on one flank and the Grassmarket on the other. But behind the rock, in its lee, the ice was sheltered, so it left a long protected ramp of softer sedimentary rock and debris trailing away to the east. Geologists call this a crag and tail, and Edinburgh's is the textbook example of the form, cited in earth science courses worldwide.

Understand that shape and you understand the city. The crag is the sheer defensive cliff the castle sits on, unassailable on three sides. The tail is the gentle downhill spine that became the Royal Mile, running from the castle down to Holyrood, with the medieval Old Town's tightly packed closes and tenements crowding along its slopes. The whole distinctive silhouette of historic Edinburgh, that dramatic ridge crowned by a fortress, was dictated by the direction a glacier happened to travel. It also explains the castle's single great weakness, the one you're walking up right now. Every other approach is cliff, so the only viable line of attack was always along the tail, from the town side, which is precisely where the defences are concentrated and where nearly every siege in the castle's history was fought and decided.

The Oldest Room in Edinburgh

Near the summit of the rock stands a small, unassuming stone building that repays a moment of attention out of all proportion to its size. It's Saint Margaret's Chapel, and at roughly nine hundred years old, dating to around eleven thirty, it's the oldest surviving building in Edinburgh, the oldest roofed structure anywhere in the city. It's a plain little Romanesque box, barely sixteen feet by ten inside, with one beautiful chevron-decorated arch separating a tiny nave from a rounded apse. In a fortress that has been demolished and rebuilt more times than almost any castle in Britain, this is the one thing that has stood, more or less continuously, since the twelfth century.

Its survival is not an accident, it's a story about reverence outlasting warfare. When Robert the Bruce took the castle in thirteen fourteen, he ordered its defences systematically slighted, torn down, so the English could never again turn them into a stronghold. Almost every wall and tower came down. The chapel was deliberately spared as consecrated ground, and that same immunity protected it through the destructions that followed, including the artillery bombardment of the Lang Siege two and a half centuries later. The great fortifications of successive kings are dust, and this modest devotional room outlived every one of them.

The Margaret it honours is a remarkable figure in her own right. She was an Anglo-Saxon princess of the old royal house of Wessex, granddaughter of an English king, who fled north after the Norman Conquest of ten sixty-six and married Malcolm the Third, King of Scots, around ten seventy. She was famously pious and charitable, and after her death she was canonised as a saint, one of very few Scottish royal saints. The chapel was built in her memory by her youngest son, King David the First, one of the great medieval Scottish monarchs. There's a nice final irony to the place. Its royal identity was eventually forgotten entirely, and for a long stretch the army used it as a gunpowder store, until the antiquary Sir Daniel Wilson recognised it for what it was in the eighteen forties and had it restored. Today it still hosts weddings and christenings, the oldest building in the city, quietly back in use.

The Lang Siege and the Buried Tower

Of the twenty-odd sieges this rock has endured, the one that shaped the castle you're actually walking through was the Lang Siege, the long siege, fought from fifteen seventy-one to fifteen seventy-three. It is worth understanding, because almost everything on the southern skyline in front of you is a direct consequence of it.

By this point Mary, Queen of Scots was already a prisoner in England, her cause in Scotland all but finished. Yet one man refused to let it die. Sir William Kirkcaldy of Grange was the most admired soldier of his generation, a veteran who had once fought against Mary, then changed sides and made himself the keeper of her castle. For two years he held this rock for a queen who was never coming back, in the teeth of a hostile government led by the Regent Morton. It was, in the end, a siege sustained by loyalty and stubbornness more than strategy.

What broke him was foreign artillery. Queen Elizabeth of England, tired of the instability on her northern border, sent heavy guns and gunners north under Sir William Drury. In the spring of fifteen seventy-three they ringed the rock with batteries and opened a bombardment that is thought to have loosed something like three thousand shots in a matter of days, the heaviest cannonade Scotland had yet seen. The target was the castle's proudest structure, David's Tower, a massive L-shaped keep begun around thirteen sixty-eight by King David the Second, the son of Robert the Bruce. Under that pounding the tower cracked, slumped, and finally collapsed in a landslide of masonry, and when it fell it choked the castle's main well beneath the rubble. With his water gone and his walls broken, Kirkcaldy surrendered. He was hanged at the Mercat Cross down in the town, and the friend who had begged him to give up in time, the reformer John Knox, had predicted almost exactly that end.

Now, the part you can see and stand on. When the fighting was over, the shattered stump of David's Tower was not cleared away. Instead the victors simply built over it, wrapping a great curved gun platform around and on top of the ruin. That is the Half Moon Battery, the tall rounded rampart that dominates the approach as you come up toward the palace. So the castle's most famous silhouette is quite literally a scar healed over a catastrophe, a Renaissance gun emplacement raised on the bones of a medieval keep.

And here is the reward for the curious. David's Tower was not destroyed so much as buried. Its lower storeys survived, sealed inside the fabric of the Half Moon Battery and forgotten for more than three centuries, until they were rediscovered in nineteen twelve. Today you can leave the daylight of the upper castle, duck through a low doorway, and descend into the cold vaulted rooms of the tower itself, six hundred and fifty years old, the very chamber where, as you'll hear, a king once hosted the darkest dinner in Scottish history. Most visitors walk right past the entrance. Don't.

Din Eidyn: The Fortress Before the Castle

Long before the first stone castle, before Malcolm and Margaret, before there was anything you would recognise as Scotland, this rock was already a stronghold. People have lived on the summit for something close to three thousand years, since the Bronze Age, and it is easy to see why. A flat-topped crag with sheer cliffs on three sides is a gift to anyone who needs to hold high ground, and the people of the Iron Age took it.

In the centuries around the Roman occupation, this whole region belonged to a British tribe the Romans called the Votadini. In their own tongue, a Celtic language ancestral to Welsh rather than to Gaelic, they and their kingdom later became known as the Gododdin, and their great fortress here bore the name Din Eidyn, which means simply the fort of Eidyn. Hold those two words, Din Eidyn, because they are the seed of the name Edinburgh. When Anglian invaders from the south seized the rock, they kept the old name Eidyn and swapped the British word for fort, din, for their own word, burh. Din Eidyn became Edin-burh became Edinburgh. The city carries the name of a vanished British kingdom in its own front teeth.

That kingdom left one astonishing thing behind, and it may be the oldest surviving poem composed in what is now Scotland. It is called Y Gododdin, attributed to a bard named Aneirin, and it dates to somewhere around the year six hundred. It tells of a war band of picked warriors who gathered here at Din Eidyn, feasted and drank in the king's hall for a year, and then rode south to attack the Angles at a place called Catraeth, thought to be Catterick in Yorkshire. The poem is a long series of elegies, because almost every one of those men was killed. Verse after verse names a warrior, praises his courage and his gold torc and his prowess, and mourns that he went to Catraeth and did not come home. Read it and you are hearing grief that is fourteen hundred years old, spoken for men who very likely mustered on the ground beneath your feet.

A note of honesty. We cannot prove that the hall in the poem stood on this exact summit, and scholars debate the details, so treat the precise location as informed tradition rather than certainty. What is certain is that the fall of Din Eidyn was recorded around the year six thirty-eight, when the Angles took the rock and the kingdom of the Gododdin collapsed. That date is one of the first solid facts in this fortress's history, and it means the site was already ancient, already fought over, already lost and won, four hundred years before the medieval castle whose ruins define the place today. Everything else you'll see here, the palace, the batteries, the crown jewels, sits on top of that far older story of a British hillfort and the poem it inspired.

Arthur's Seat and the Family of Volcanoes

Stand on the ramparts and look east across the city, and you'll see a great green hill rising above the rooftops, with a line of dark cliffs running along its flank. That is Arthur's Seat, and its crags are the ones you'll be climbing in a few days. It's worth knowing, up here, that the hill you're standing on and the hill you're looking at are relatives. They belong to the same family of volcanoes, born in the same fit of geological violence around three hundred and forty million years ago, when this corner of Scotland sat in the tropics near the equator and the ground was tearing and erupting. Recent dating of the lavas puts the activity at roughly three hundred and thirty-five to three hundred and forty million years old. Arthur's Seat was the larger volcanic complex, and Castle Rock, geologists reckon, is the eroded root of a smaller vent, a satellite of the same system. The two rocks are cousins, cut from the same ancient fire.

Both were then sculpted by the same ice, which is why they share that lopsided profile, a blunt cliff facing west into the oncoming glacier and a long tapering tail streaming away east. On Arthur's Seat, the tail is the ridge that carries you gently up to the summit, and the western cliffs are the Salisbury Crags, that sweeping curtain of rock you can see from here.

And those Salisbury Crags are not just scenery. They are one of the birthplaces of modern science. In the seventeen eighties, an Edinburgh farmer and thinker named James Hutton walked those crags again and again, and read in them something no one had quite grasped before. He found a place, still called Hutton's Section, where molten rock had clearly forced its way sideways into older layers of sediment, baking and disrupting them. That could only mean the rocks had formed at wildly different times, by different processes, heat from below as well as deposit from above, and that the earth must be almost unimaginably old, far older than the few thousand years people then assumed. Hutton is remembered as the father of modern geology, and his most famous line, gazing at deep time, was that he could see no vestige of a beginning and no prospect of an end. The whole idea that our planet has an immense, unfolding history, the idea Darwin would later need for evolution, was worked out in part on the cliffs you're looking at right now.

So when you climb Arthur's Seat later in the trip, you won't just be bagging a viewpoint. You'll be walking a sister volcano to this one, over the very outcrops where a farmer first read the true age of the world. Two extinct volcanoes, one crowned with a fortress and a thousand years of kings, the other left wild and green, both of them the same three-hundred-and-forty-million-year-old fire, both carved by the

same river of ice. From up here you can see the whole family at once.

The Honours and the Stone: Objects of State

The Honours of Scotland — crown, scepter, and sword of state, in use together by 1543 — are the oldest surviving crown jewels in Britain, precisely because of two episodes of concealment. When Cromwell invaded in 1650, having already melted the English regalia, the Honours were smuggled from besieged Dunnottar Castle — by tradition lowered down the cliff and carried away by a minister's wife amid bundles of flax — and buried beneath the floor of Kinneff church for nine years. After the Union of 1707 they were locked in a chest in the Crown Room and forgotten for a hundred and eleven years, until Walter Scott — already busy inventing modern Scotland's self-image — obtained a royal warrant in 1818 and opened the sealed room to find them intact. The Stone of Destiny beside them carries even more freight: the inauguration seat of Scottish kings at Scone, seized by Edward the First in 1296 and installed under the Coronation Chair at Westminster as a deliberate statement that Scotland's kingship had been annexed. Every English and British monarch for seven centuries was crowned above it. The 1950 Christmas raid by four Glasgow students — who broke the stone extracting it, hid it, and eventually left it at Arbroath Abbey, site of Scotland's 1320 declaration of independence — embarrassed the state so much that prosecution was declined. The stone returned officially in 1996, was moved to a new home in Perth in 2024, and still travels south for coronations, most recently in 2023. Note the sightline as you leave the Crown Room: these objects sit thirty meters from the room where James the Sixth was born in 1566 — the king who would unite the crowns of the two countries that fought over all of it.

Tell Me More: Scott's Treasure Hunt and Wartime Burial

The 1818 rediscovery of the Honours was theatre directed by Walter Scott, and he knew exactly what he was staging. Post-Union Scotland had spent a century as "North Britain," its national symbols dormant; Scott — then the most famous writer alive and the great impresario of romantic Scottishness — obtained the Prince Regent's warrant to open the sealed Crown Room, gathered commissioners, and broke into the chest before witnesses. His own account describes the moment of lifting the linen and the crowd outside cheering as word spread; one commissioner reaching to place the crown jokingly on a young lady's head drew from Scott a genuinely fierce rebuke — to him these were sacred objects, not props. The find fed directly into his 1822 masterpiece: stage-managing George the Fourth's visit to Edinburgh, the first by a reigning monarch in nearly two centuries, an orgy of invented tartan pageantry (the portly king in a kilt over flesh-colored tights) that rehabilitated Highland dress a generation after it had been banned, and essentially created the tartan-shortbread iconography Scotland has profitably resented ever since. The Second World War buriale: in 1939, fearing invasion, the Honours were hidden within the castle — the crown in a medieval latrine closet beneath David's Tower floor, the case buried elsewhere — with sealed instructions deposited across the Atlantic in Canada, so that even if Britain fell, the location would survive. The regalia thus waited out the Luftwaffe a few meters from their display case, in the fabric of the rock itself — the third time in their history that Scotland's crown survived by burial.

The Birth of a King

Thirty metres from the Crown Room, in the royal apartments of the palace block, is a tiny panelled chamber that changed the course of British history, because a king was born in it. On the nineteenth of June, fifteen sixty-six, Mary, Queen of Scots gave birth here to a son, James. It's a startlingly small and modest room for so consequential an event, and the panelling and painted ceiling you see commemorate the birth. Stand in it and it's hard not to feel the compression of the space against the scale of what followed.

The circumstances were anything but serene. Mary's reign was unravelling into violence and paranoia.

Just three months earlier, while she was six months pregnant, a group of armed conspirators, led by her own husband Lord Darnley, had burst into her supper room at Holyrood and stabbed her Italian secretary David Rizzio to death almost in front of her, some said to frighten her into miscarriage. Darnley was jealous, unstable, and politically dangerous, and he openly cast doubt on whether the child was even his. Tradition holds that Mary, stung by the slander, presented the infant to Darnley and declared before witnesses that this was his son and the son of no other man, a public act of legitimation aimed squarely at the rumours.

What that baby became is the reason the room matters. Within thirteen months Mary was forced to abdicate and the infant was crowned James the Sixth, King of Scots, at Stirling, a toddler monarch with a series of regents ruling in his name. He never saw his mother again, and she was eventually executed in England by her cousin Elizabeth. Yet it was James who inherited everything in the end. When the childless Elizabeth the First died in sixteen oh three, the crown of England passed to him, and the man born in this cramped Edinburgh room became James the First of England as well as James the Sixth of Scots, uniting the two crowns under a single sovereign for the first time. So the long story you've just heard in the Crown Room, of Scotland and England fighting over regalia, thrones, and a lump of sandstone, has one of its great hinges right here, in a chamber you could cross in three paces.

The Stone's New Home

One correction worth carrying into the Crown Room, because guidebooks and memories lag behind the facts. The Stone of Destiny is no longer here. After nearly three decades on display beside the Honours, following its official return from Westminster in nineteen ninety-six, the Stone left Edinburgh Castle for good in March twenty twenty-four. Its last day on the rock was the tenth of March, and it now sits about forty miles north, in the newly opened Perth Museum, which welcomed the public on the thirtieth of March that year. So if you came expecting to see the Stone next to the crown and sceptre, that's why it isn't there.

The move was deliberate and, in its way, a homecoming. The Stone's deepest associations are not with Edinburgh at all but with Scone, just outside Perth, where the medieval kings of Scots were inaugurated seated on or beside it, going back to the ninth century. Edward the First of England carried it off in twelve ninety-six as a trophy of conquest, and it spent seven centuries under the Coronation Chair at Westminster, becoming a fixture of English and then British coronations. Its return to Perthshire in twenty twenty-four marked the first time in more than seven hundred years that the Stone had come back to the landscape it belonged to. Perth built it a purpose-designed gallery inside a restored former city hall, the centrepiece of a twenty-seven-million-pound museum, and visitor numbers surged from the moment it opened.

There's a persistent legend you may hear, and it deserves the honest treatment. When those four students took the Stone from Westminster in nineteen fifty and had it repaired, some have claimed that a copy was made and that the stone handed back to the authorities, the one that travelled here and now sits in Perth, is a replica, with the real Stone hidden away in Scotland. It's a wonderful story, and there's no credible evidence for it, so treat it as folklore rather than fact. What's certain is more interesting anyway. Even now, settled in Perth, the Stone still isn't allowed to rest. Under a standing agreement it must travel south for coronations, and it did exactly that in twenty twenty-three for the crowning of King Charles the Third, journeying to Westminster Abbey and back. After more than a thousand years, this battered block of sandstone is still on the move.

The Gun, the Guns, and the Shrine

The One O’Clock Gun, fired daily except Sundays since 1861, is Greenwich’s time-ball logic adapted to Scottish weather: Leith’s shipping needed a time signal, fog defeats visual signals, so Edinburgh added an audible one — originally triggered by a clock connected to the Nelson Monument’s time ball on Calton Hill by what was claimed as the world’s longest telegraph wire. The one o’clock hour is traditionally explained as economy — one round instead of twelve — which Edinburghers repeat about themselves with pride. Sound-lag maps were genuinely published so citizens could correct for their distance from the castle. Mons Meg, up by St Margaret’s Chapel, is the castle’s other famous barrel: a six-tonne bombard forged at Mons in 1449 and given to James the Second in 1457, capable of throwing a hundred-fifty-kilo gunstone some three kilometers — cutting-edge superweapon of its day, retired after bursting while firing a salute in 1681. But the castle’s emotional center is quieter: the Scottish National War Memorial, opened in 1927 in a converted barrack block, holds the rolls of honour naming every Scottish casualty of the First World War and after — around a hundred fifty thousand from 1914 to 18 alone, a staggering share of a small nation. The shrine stands on the rock’s highest point, the casket of names resting directly on exposed bedrock deliberately left protruding through the marble floor. Even with kids in tow, give it five minutes; it is one of the great war memorials of the world.

Tell Me More: Reading the War Memorial

A little context multiplies the Scottish National War Memorial’s force. Scotland’s Great War losses were proportionally among the worst of any combatant nation — commonly cited at around a quarter of those who served, against lower rates for the UK overall — driven by the Scottish regiments’ heavy use as assault infantry and by recruitment rates that emptied whole communities; some Highland glens and fishing villages lost most of a generation of men in single battalions, on single days. The “pals” pattern made it worse: men enlisted together, served together, died together — McCrae’s Battalion, raised in Edinburgh in 1914 around the Heart of Midlothian football team (the club whose name you saw in the cobbles), lost three-quarters of its strength on the first day of the Somme; the team had been top of the league when its players enlisted en masse. The memorial’s design absorbs this: Robert Lorimer’s 1927 conversion of a barrack block was deliberately not triumphal — no victory figures, but a shrine where the casket of Rolls of Honour rests on raw basalt left protruding through the marble floor, the rock of Scotland itself bearing the names; the stained glass includes scenes of industrial war, women munition workers among them, and the bronze friezes include the animals — horses, mules, carrier pigeons, even mice used to detect gas. Every name is findable: the Rolls are maintained and updated to the present day, and staff will help visitors locate a family name. For American visitors, one resonance: the memorial predates the US national practice — there was no equivalent in Washington until decades later — and its influence on commonwealth memorials worldwide was immediate and lasting.

Mons Meg: Biography of a Superweapon

Up by Saint Margaret’s Chapel sits a squat, monstrous iron barrel that deserves a fuller introduction, because Mons Meg was once among the most fearsome machines on earth. She’s a medieval bombard, a siege cannon built to smash stone walls, and she was cutting-edge military technology of a kind that was rewriting warfare. She was forged in fourteen forty-nine at Mons, in what is now Belgium, by a gunmaker working for Philip the Good, Duke of Burgundy, then one of the richest and most sophisticated rulers in Europe. The Duke gave her to James the Second of Scotland in fourteen fifty-seven as a diplomatic gift, a gesture of alliance, and for a poor northern kingdom to receive a weapon like this was a genuine coup.

Look at how she’s made, because it tells you her age. Meg isn’t cast as a single piece of bronze like later

cannon. She's built the old way, from long wrought-iron staves welded lengthwise and then bound with a series of thick iron hoops shrunk on around them, the same principle as a wooden barrel, which is in fact where the word barrel for a gun comes from. She weighs around six tonnes, her bore is twenty inches across, and she could hurl a gunstone weighing about one hundred and fifty kilos over a distance of some two miles. Moving her was its own ordeal. Contemporary records suggest she could manage only about three miles a day, hauled by teams of men and oxen, so she was a strategic asset dragged laboriously to a siege, not a field gun.

James the Fourth took her to war, notably to the siege of Norham Castle in fourteen ninety-seven, but her working life was already closing. Guns evolved fast, and heavy immobile bombards were soon obsolete. Her end as a functioning weapon came in sixteen eighty-one, when she burst while firing a ceremonial salute, splitting her barrel, and you can still see the damage. She might have vanished entirely, because in seventeen fifty-four she was carted off to the Tower of London with other redundant Scottish ordnance. That she came home is thanks largely to Sir Walter Scott, the same tireless romantic who rediscovered the Honours, who campaigned for her return. In eighteen twenty-nine, by order of George the Fourth, Mons Meg was shipped back to Edinburgh in triumph, and the city gave her a hero's welcome. She's been on the rock ever since, a retired giant.

The Great Hall: Oak and Power

Step into the Great Hall and let your eye go straight up, because the ceiling is the whole point. It's a hammerbeam roof, a masterpiece of medieval carpentry completed around fifteen hundred and eleven for James the Fourth, the most brilliant and cultured of the Stewart kings. A hammerbeam roof is an engineering conjuring trick. Instead of a single tie-beam spanning the full width, which would need timbers longer than any tree could supply, the weight is carried on short brackets, the hammerbeams, that jut inward from each wall and pass the load down through the walls themselves. The result is a broad, open, soaring space with no pillars cluttering the floor, roofed in dark oak that has hung there for more than five centuries. It is one of only two medieval hammerbeam halls to survive in Scotland, and it is the finest.

Look closely where the beams meet the walls and you'll find the carved stone corbels that support them, decorated with Renaissance detail, thistles, and emblems of James the Fourth. This was a deliberate statement of magnificence. James was building a European court, cutting-edge in its ambition, and a hall like this was propaganda in timber and stone, meant to overawe ambassadors and remind the Scottish nobility exactly whose roof they dined under.

There is a piece of theatre worth hunting for. High on the wall by the fireplace, at the west end, is a small rectangular opening screened by a grille. It's known as the laird's lug, the lord's ear. The tradition, and it is tradition rather than documented fact, is that the king could sit hidden in a small chamber behind it and eavesdrop on the talk in the hall below, listening for flattery, disloyalty, or plots. Whether or not any monarch actually used it as a listening post, it is exactly the kind of detail that tells you how a royal hall really worked, a room where a careless word could cost you.

The armour and weapons bristling on the walls are a later flourish, a Victorian arrangement assembled when the hall was restored, not a medieval survival, so admire them as decoration rather than as the room James knew. And there's a humbler truth beneath the grandeur. For most of its long life this hall was not a place of feasts at all. After the wars of the seventeenth century it was carved up into a barracks and later a military hospital, its glorious roof hidden above a false ceiling, soldiers slung in bunks where kings had banqueted. The hall you see was rescued and restored only in the eighteen nineties, funded by the publisher William Nelson, and returned to something like its original splendour. So you're standing in a genuine Renaissance royal hall, but one that spent centuries as an army dormitory, its magnificence sleeping in the dark overhead until the Victorians thought to look up.

The Esplanade, the Loch, and the Witches

The long flat parade ground you crossed to reach the gatehouse, the esplanade, is a comfortable modern approach, and in July you may find it half-covered in scaffolding grandstands going up for the Military Tattoo. But it has a much darker past worth carrying with you, because this genteel forecourt was for two centuries one of the principal killing grounds of the Scottish witch panic.

Scotland executed witches with a ferocity out of all proportion to its size. Between the fifteen hundreds and the early seventeen hundreds, something like four thousand people were put on trial for witchcraft here, a rate far higher per head than in England, and the great majority of the accused were women. Of those, several hundred were executed on Castlehill, on and around the ground beneath your feet at the top of the Royal Mile. The commonly cited figure is more than three hundred. The method was grimly standard. The condemned was tied to a stake, strangled first, and only then burned, the ashes raked into the earth so there could be no grave. As you leave, look on the wall of the building facing the lower end of the esplanade for the Witches' Well, a small cast-iron fountain put up in eighteen ninety-four to mark, quietly, what happened here. Most visitors walk straight past it.

Now turn and look over the north wall, down to the green valley that holds the gardens, the railway, and the shops of Princes Street. For most of the castle's history that was not a garden at all. It was a lake, the Nor Loch, deliberately created around fourteen sixty when James the Third had the hollow flooded to seal off the castle's northern flank. It was a defensive moat on a civic scale, and for centuries it also served as the Old Town's rubbish tip and open sewer, a stagnant, stinking sheet of water that no one would drink from. The loch was finally drained between roughly eighteen thirteen and eighteen twenty, and the reclaimed ground became Princes Street Gardens, so the elegant valley you're admiring is a drained medieval defence.

There's a legend that ties the loch to the witches, the idea that suspected witches were ducked in the Nor Loch to test their guilt, thrown in bound, on the ghastly logic that the innocent would sink and the guilty float. You'll hear it told with great confidence on the ghost tours. The honest position is that while the loch was certainly used to punish and humiliate offenders by ducking, there is little solid evidence that this water-test was actually used to identify witches in Scottish trials, so treat the dramatic version as folklore. The sober history is dark enough without it. From this one spot you can take in a drained defensive lake, a Renaissance gun battery built over a bombarded keep, and the burning ground of hundreds of women, all of it now wearing the calm face of a tourist attraction.

The Black Dinner

If you descend into the old vaulted rooms of David's Tower, spare a thought for what happened there in November of fourteen forty, because it is one of the most infamous acts of treachery in Scottish history, and if it sounds oddly familiar, that is not a coincidence.

Scotland at that moment had a child on the throne. James the Second was ten years old, and real power was being fought over by a knot of ambitious men around him, chiefly the Chancellor, Sir William Crichton, keeper of this castle, and Sir Alexander Livingston, who held the young king. The great threat to both of them was the House of Douglas, the Black Douglasses, a family so rich and so heavily armed that they rivalled the crown itself. The new head of that family was William, the sixth Earl of Douglas, and he was just sixteen, a proud, popular young man riding at the head of a private army. To the men running the country he was intolerable, a boy who might grow into a kingmaker or a king-breaker.

So they invited him to dinner. In late November fourteen forty, the young earl and his even younger brother David were welcomed into Edinburgh Castle to dine with the boy king in the hall of David's Tower. By the laws of hospitality, of guest and host, they were as safe at that table as anywhere on earth. The two Douglas boys and the child king ate together, and by several accounts the meal was warm and friendly, the young men at their ease.

Then came the sign. According to the chroniclers, a black bull's head was carried in and set upon the table before the earl. In the grim symbolism of the age, the bull's head meant death, and everyone in that room who was old enough understood it at once. The Douglasses were seized. The ten-year-old king, the stories say, wept and pleaded for his guests, for he liked them and knew what was owed to men at his own table, but he was a child and he was overruled. The two brothers were dragged out onto Castlehill, given the barest mockery of a trial, and beheaded on the spot. The elder was sixteen, the younger perhaps no more than a boy of ten or eleven himself.

It was a calculated political murder, a way of decapitating an over-mighty family in a single evening, and it poisoned Scottish politics for a generation. The Douglasses did not forget, and the feud between crown and family ran on in blood for years, until eventually a grown James the Second would stab another Douglas earl to death with his own hands in another castle.

Here's the modern twist. The novelist George R. R. Martin has said openly that this dinner, guests slaughtered under the sacred protection of hospitality, was one of his inspirations for the Red Wedding in *Game of Thrones*. So the scene that made millions of television viewers gasp has its root right here, in a real crime committed in a real room you can walk into, six hundred years ago, over a boy king's tears.

The Prisons in the Rock

Beneath Crown Square, in the cool vaulted cellars that honeycomb the heart of the castle, is one of the most affecting corners of the whole site, and one of the easiest to hurry past. For most of the seventeen hundreds and into the early eighteen hundreds, these vaults were a war prison, and the men held here were not criminals but captured enemy combatants, prisoners of war swept up in the long chain of eighteenth-century conflicts.

Britain in this period was fighting almost everyone, and it improvised a network of war prisons to hold the men it took. Edinburgh Castle became one of them from the Seven Years' War in the seventeen fifties onward, and over the decades it held a strikingly international cast, Frenchmen and Spaniards, Dutchmen and Danes, Italians, Poles, Irishmen, and, in significant numbers, Americans. Most were sailors, because sea war generated prisoners by the shipload, and captured crews were marched inland and locked in the rock. The great majority of the Americans arrived during the War of Independence, taken from privateers and warships, and here is a connection worth savouring. The most feared American raider of that war was John Paul Jones, a captain born on the Scottish coast just down the Solway, who terrorised British shipping and even raided the shores he had grown up on. It is believed that at least two of Jones's own crewmen ended up imprisoned in these very vaults. Men who had sailed with the founding hero of the United States Navy sat out the war under this Scottish rock.

Life down here was boredom punctuated by ingenuity. The prisoners organised themselves, ran their own rough economy, and above all they made things. Using bone, straw, wood, and whatever scraps they could gather, they carved and built with real skill, model ships, decorated boxes, dominoes and chess sets, straw marquetry, little worked trinkets. And crucially they were allowed to sell them. On most days a market operated, roughly from mid-morning to mid-afternoon, when townspeople could come to a barrier and buy the prisoners' handiwork, which gave the men a trickle of money for tobacco and small comforts. Some of those objects survive in the collection, astonishingly fine work from men with nothing but time and their hands.

Look, too, at the heavy wooden doors preserved in the reconstructed prison, because the prisoners left their mark on them directly, scratching names, ships, and images into the timber. One carving in particular has become quietly famous, and it's worth seeking out, an early rendering of the American flag cut by a homesick prisoner around seventeen eighty. It is thought to be one of the oldest surviving depictions of the Stars and Stripes anywhere outside North America, a scrap of a brand-new country's identity, carved in a dungeon an ocean away from home.

The vaults' career as a prison ended not long after a notorious mass escape in eighteen eleven, which finally convinced the authorities that a hole in a cliff was no longer a secure place to keep desperate men. The prison closed, the war wound down, and the cellars fell silent. What remains is one of the best-preserved war prisons in Britain, and standing in it, in the cool and the dim, you're closer to the ordinary human texture of these old wars than anywhere else on the rock.